

Zouk Assignment — My Process & Interview Notes

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The 60-second version

I audited Zouk's website before touching any task, then solved the four tasks one by one against one first-time buyer. Every decision traces back to the audit or to that buyer.

How to use this doc: read each section once before the interview. On the day, use the **Say this** pointers under each task. They are short enough to glance at mid-conversation.

If they ask "walk me through it" — say this:

- I started with an audit, not the tasks. The audit judged the site through one person: a first-time buyer landing from an Instagram ad, on a phone, with no Zouk vocabulary.
- The biggest insight: Zouk mostly doesn't lack content. Its best assets (the size infographic, the what-fits photo) exist but sit in the wrong place, and its product data contradicts itself.
- **Task 1, product page:** reordered the page around "will it fit", said every spec once, added a print switcher, and put the return terms next to the button.
- **Task 2, collection banners:** locked an Indian Heritage direction, because the handcrafted print is the one thing competitors can't copy.
- **Task 3, navigation:** rebuilt the menu into clear groups (Shop, Offers, Browse by, Account) so each level offers one kind of choice.
- **Task 4, Make Your Own Combo:** a "set" builder where the customer picks the items, sees the saving update live, and adds gift options, instead of accepting a pair Zouk chose.
- Throughout: honest over persuasive. No fake urgency, no hidden terms.

My process: the same eight steps for every task

I ran the same sequence on all four tasks, so every design decision has a reason written down before the design exists.

1. **Audit first.** Before reading the tasks closely, I audited the live site on mobile and desktop and wrote down the frictions. The tasks then became "which frictions does this task have to answer?"

2. **One persona per task.** A specific person with a situation, not a demographic: Meher (Task 1), Riya (Task 3), Rohan (Task 4).
3. **Assumptions, stated.** I had no analytics or user research, so I listed what I was assuming and how Zouk could check each one quickly.
4. **Decode the brief.** I read the brief word by word to find the tension in it. Example: "faster" and "more confident" pull against each other.
5. **Scope.** What I'm designing, what I'm not, and the constraints I'm working inside rather than trying to fix.
6. **Competition and principles.** What competitors do better, what I would not copy, and 3-4 rules that settle arguments between two layouts.
7. **Solution, module by module.** For each piece: what it is today, what I changed, why, and what it should move.
8. **Success metrics and edge states.** How Zouk would know it worked, what must not get worse, and what happens when data is missing.

Say this:

- "I didn't start designing until I could state the problem in one sentence."
- "Everything is traceable. Each change points back to a friction from the audit or to the persona."
- "I had no data, so I made my assumptions explicit and checkable, rather than pretending to know."
- "I changed my mind twice during the audit, and I kept both versions so you can see the reasoning."

The audit: 13 frictions, judged through one first-time buyer

The audit came first because all four tasks sit on the same few problems. Finding them once meant each task could build on the last, instead of starting from zero.

Who I audited for: a first-time buyer who lands from an Instagram ad, on a phone, one-handed, with no Zouk vocabulary. She is spending ₹1,400–2,800, so it's a considered purchase and she needs proof. Out of scope: the app (I assumed it serves repeat buyers), checkout and stores.

#	Friction	Severity	Feeds
1	Menu built on model names (Saisha, OOO, Harriet), not needs	High	Tasks 3, 4

#	Friction	Severity	Feeds
2	Reviews pooled across prints and even product types (wallet reviews under an office bag)	High	Task 1
3	Specs contradict each other; "capacity" is just outer dimensions multiplied	High	Task 1
4	Collection grid shows about 50 prints but never says which bag is which	High	Task 1
5	Filters have no laptop size, capacity or dimensions	High	Tasks 1, 4
6	Return policy is strict, hidden, and two policy pages disagree	High	Tasks 1, 4
7	Duplicate filter values ("Black" and "black") split results	Medium	Quick win
8	One menu level mixes ten different kinds of choice	High	Task 3
9	"What is this bag for" built twice, in two vocabularies	High	Task 3
10	Product page can't show the same bag in another print	High	Tasks 1, 4
11	The best asset (size infographic) is buried at image 5 of 13	Medium	Task 1
12	Product page cross-sells at random; the cart does it well	Medium	Tasks 1, 4
13	Bundle savings are only visible in the cart, after committing	High	Task 4

What I'd keep: the size infographic, the what-fits photography, free shipping and COD reassurance, and the craft story behind the prints. Most of my proposals move these to where the decision happens rather than replacing them.

How I kept it honest: every finding says what I observed, what I inferred, and what Zouk should verify. I also withdrew claims that didn't hold up on a live re-check, such as "cards show no laptop fit".

Say this:

- "The audit wasn't a checklist. I judged every issue by what it costs one specific person."

- "The headline finding is that Zouk doesn't mostly lack content. Its best content is in the wrong place, and its product data contradicts itself."
- "The capacity number is the outer dimensions multiplied together. I checked it on two bags, and both matched to two decimal places."
- "I changed my position twice, on navigation and on the grid, and I kept the argument that changed my mind."
- "Some fixes are data, not design. Friction 7 is an afternoon with a spreadsheet, and I said so."

Task 1: the product page answers "will it fit" first

The product page doesn't need more content. Its best proof is buried and its numbers disagree, so I reordered the page around the buyer's first question and said every fact once.

The brief: help a customer evaluate the product faster and with greater confidence (fit, dimensions, laptop compatibility, benefits, material, delivery).

Persona — Meher, 27, Mumbai, consultant. She sees a mandala-print bag in an Instagram ad at 11 pm and lands on that product page. She needs to know her 15.6" laptop, a bottle and lunch fit, and that the bag looks professional. She knows nothing about Zouk, and she's afraid of wasting ₹1,900.

How I read the brief:

- **"Faster" and "more confident" pull against each other.** More proof usually means more to read. So I treated it as a hierarchy problem: more certainty from less effort.
- **"May not immediately understand" is not "cannot find".** The size infographic and the what-fits photo already exist, sitting at image 5 of 13.
- **Six brief items are really three questions:** Will it work for me? Why this bag? Can I trust this purchase? Three of the six are the first question, so that's where the weight goes.
- **Part of it isn't design.** The same bag says 13 L, 15 L and 13.8 L. That's a data problem, so I designed assuming one source of truth.

Competition (Lino Perros, Miraggio, Mokobara): Mokobara is the benchmark. It states laptop fit at two levels, labels dimensions as external, and shows a delivery date before asking for a pincode. Zouk's edge: named craft prints nobody else has, the best fit infographic of the four, and the lowest price. I won't copy urgency tricks ("56 people viewing", countdowns) or stacked discounts.

Four principles:

1. Answer "will it fit" in the first screen.

2. Promote before you create.
3. The print is the hero, and it carries its story.
4. Show the cost of being wrong before she pays.

The solution, module by module:

Module	What I changed	Why
Gallery	Size and what-fits images moved to positions 2 and 3; labelled thumbnails instead of dots; a print switcher showing all 19 prints	The best fit proof was 5 blind swipes away, and "right bag, wrong print" had nowhere to go
Title	Split into plain name, print name, and a one-line craft teaser	A first-timer can't tell which word is the product; the plain name also helps search
Will it fit?	One block: laptop fit, capacity, dimensions, weight, each said once	Three contradicting numbers kill trust in every other number
Price	One consistent format; a struck-through price only for a real discount	No invented "was" prices
Delivery & returns	Added a fourth trust line with the real return terms, next to free shipping and COD	Confidence has two halves: getting it, and what happens if it's wrong
Personalisation	Moved below the button; trade-off stated beside it ("not eligible for return or COD")	She shouldn't lose her recourse without seeing it
Print story	A full craft story, placed after the decision block	It decides which bag to pick, so it shouldn't delay the decision
Reviews	Split into Design and Product reviews, with honest pool labels and fit tags like "laptop compatible"	The best fit proof is a stranger's review, buried in a pool with wallet reviews
Pair it with	The cart's curated add-ons, moved up to the product page	Replaces men's wallets under a women's bag

Trade-offs to own:

- **The print switcher can slow people down.** I chose a better decision over a faster one, and would measure time-to-cart separately for switcher users.
- **Showing the strict return terms may cost some conversions.** Honest beats a buyer who feels misled later.

Success metrics: time from landing to Add to Cart; gallery swipes before adding to cart; returns and support questions about size or fit (the one I'd watch first); add-to-cart rate from Instagram traffic. Guardrails: overall conversion holds, and the story doesn't slow the purchase.

Edge states rule: if a module's content is missing, it scales down or doesn't render. It never shows a placeholder or a half-true version.

Say this:

- "The page didn't need more. It needed its best assets in the right order."
- "I grouped six brief items into three questions, and half the brief was one question: will it fit."
- "The capacity number isn't a capacity. It's a bounding box."
- "The print switcher is a deliberate trade-off: a better decision over a faster one."
- "The story sits after the decision block. Fit answers whether she can buy; the story answers which one."
- "I'd watch fit-related returns first, because a discount or a strong ad week can't move that number."

Task 2: banners that lead with the one thing only Zouk has

The live banner isn't broken, it's generic. Both of my banners lead with the handcrafted print, because that is Zouk's real differentiator.

The brief: two mobile banners (390×160) for one collection. A sale-led banner communicates an offer; a concept-led banner communicates a use case or benefit.

What I found first: I checked Zouk's live banner before writing anything. It works — clean layout, legible type, a working offer block. But it could belong to almost any accessories brand. Nothing in it says handcrafted, Indian or print-led.

Why aesthetics is the lever: the Aesthetic-Usability Effect. People see a considered design as more usable and more trustworthy, even when the product behind it hasn't changed. A generic banner undersells a product page that, after Task 1, is genuinely better.

Direction, locked: Indian Heritage.

- **The print is what no one can copy.** Lino Perros, Miraggio and Mokobara all sell colourways. None sells a named craft print.
- **Warm and grounded, not opulent.** The near-black luxury look in reference images belongs to a bridal price tier that ₹1,600–1,900 everyday bags can't claim. Zouk's teal and cream carry the palette, and the bag stays the hero.
- **Lead with the USP.** The banner is often seen first, so it opens with the brand's truest claim instead of saving it for later.

The two banners:

- **Sale-led:** the offer is the headline, but it sits on the print, so the deal still looks like Zouk.
- **Concept-led:** built around the use case or benefit, with the print shown large enough to read as a craft object, not a pattern.

Say this:

- "I didn't assume the banner was bad. I checked it. It isn't broken, it's generic."
- "The lever here is aesthetics, and there's a named reason: the Aesthetic-Usability Effect."
- "Both banners carry the same USP, because a banner is often the first thing a visitor sees."
- "I deliberately avoided the opulent reference look. It belongs to a price tier Zouk can't honestly claim."

Open item for you: add one line on each banner's exact headline, offer and visual choices, so you can describe them from memory.

Task 3: a menu grouped into four zones, so each level offers one kind of choice

The old menu mixed thirteen items of ten different kinds, and hid whole categories. I regrouped it into Shop, Browse by, Offers and Account. Every product type is still one tap from opening the drawer.

The brief: redesign Zouk's mobile navigation so customers can discover and reach products more easily. I was free to change the information architecture.

Persona — Riya, 26, Pune. She searched "handmade Indian print bags for women" and landed on Zouk for the first time. She has no product or category in mind. She opens the menu early because it's her map of what Zouk sells.

How I read the brief:

- **"Free to change the IA" is a real invitation.** Tidying labels would answer a smaller question than the one asked.
- **"Discover" and "reach" are two different jobs.** Browsing needs prompts and inspiration; reaching needs speed. Both have to work.

Frictions it answers: 1 (model names mean nothing to her), 8 (one level, ten kinds of choice; slings only reachable through a BOGO promotion; Travel and Zouk For Men hidden under New Arrivals) and 9 (occasion described in two vocabularies that share three words).

The new drawer:

Zone	What's in it	What it does for her
Shop	Bags, Backpacks, Travel, Wallets & small bags, Zouk For Men, Gift Boxes, Accessories	Every kind of product at a glance; Slings, Travel and Men get permanent homes
Browse by	Print (first), Occasion, Budget, New Arrivals, Collections & collabs	Where exploring happens; Print leads because it's why she came
Offers	Sling BOGO, Under ₹999, Combos, Big Bag Festival	Promotions stay visible but stop taking permanent menu seats
Account	Tribe, Stores, About, Care guide, Reviews, Contact, Sign in	Quiet, at the bottom

Key decisions:

- **Section labels, not tappable parents**, so grouping costs no extra tap.
- **Plain shape names first, model names second.** "Crossbody" tells her what the bag is; "Zoe" doesn't. All five baguettes now sit together.
- **I placed the person-named slings by reading each model's own product page**, not by guessing.
- **One reconciled list of eight occasions**, shared by the menu and the filter.
- **Laptop size stays a filter**, not a menu destination.
- **I checked about 90 live menu links**, so every product line has a home.
- **One structure for mobile and desktop**, with one page behind every label, which fixes split search ranking and analytics.

Success metrics: taps from opening the drawer to a category; drawer opened then closed with no tap; share of sessions using Browse by; visitors viewing more than one category.

Say this:

- "A menu level should offer one kind of choice. Zouk's offered ten."
- "Slings, a core category, were only reachable through a discount."
- "The section labels aren't levels, so grouping costs nothing."
- "Print leads Browse by because print is why this visitor came."
- "I didn't guess where products belong. I read each product page and checked every live menu link."
- "The fix isn't only the drawer. One navigation source for mobile and desktop stops the two drifting apart."

Task 4: a "set" builder where the customer chooses and sees the saving live

Zouk's 130 combos are pairs Zouk chose, and their saving only shows up in the cart. My feature lets the customer build their own set, with matching done for them and the saving visible at every step.

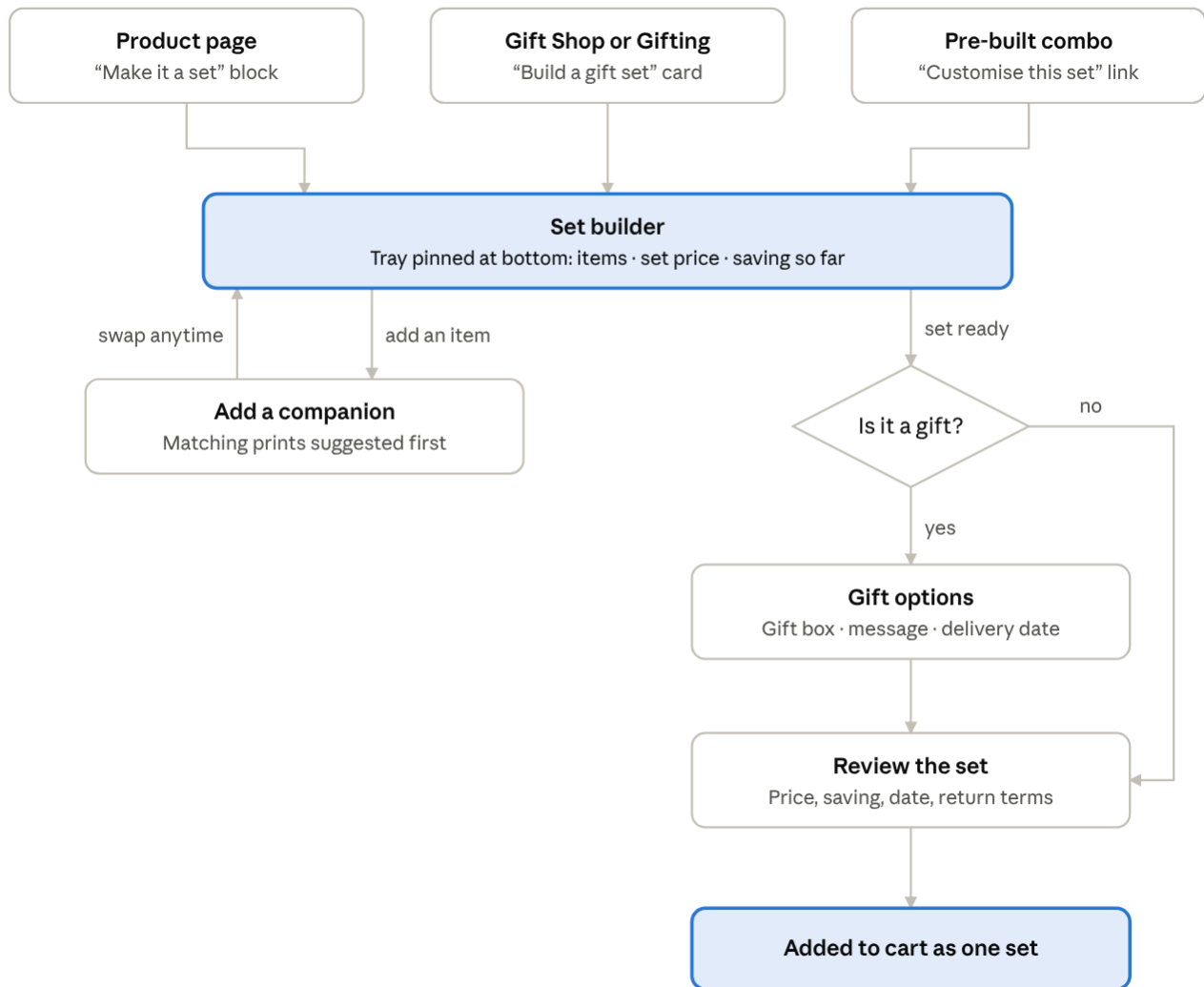
The brief: design the mobile experience for "Make Your Own Combo", where customers bundle multiple products for a better combined price. A user flow or a wireframe.

Persona — Rohan, 34, Hyderabad, software engineer. He's buying an anniversary gift for his wife, 10 days away. He knows why he's buying but not what to pick, and doesn't know a baguette from a satchel. He's worried about delivery in time and about her not liking it.

How I read the brief:

- **"Create their own"** puts the customer in charge, not Zouk.
- **"Better combined price"** only works if the customer can see it while choosing.
- **"New feature" but not a blank page:** the cart already applies buy-one-get-one and shows savings well. It just happens too late.
- **Freedom costs effort:** a builder that asks too many questions turns shopping into a form.

Three ways in, one set builder, one exit into the existing cart



Make it a set · user flow, 3 entries, 1 decision

He can enter from a product page, from gifting, or from an existing combo, and every path ends in Zouk's existing cart.

Key decisions:

- **A set tray pinned to the bottom** shows items, set price and saving after every choice ("Add 1 more to save 10%").
- **Matching is done for him:** companions are suggested by the same print first, then prints from the same family.
- **Swap anything, anytime**, which the 130 fixed combos can't do.
- **Gift options in one toggle**, with a delivery date shown before any pincode.
- **Return terms stated plainly at review**, because he's buying for someone else.
- **One name, "set"**, because "combo" already means the fixed pairs, and one offer already has three names (BOGO, Buy Any 2, B1G1).

- **Up to 5 items, with the saving capped at 3.** Three is where a gift becomes a set. Five matches Zouk's existing five-piece combo. Ten would be a bulk order, which Corporate Gifting already handles.
- **Offers never stack;** the better price applies automatically.
- **Hick's Law:** 3–4 suggested categories based on the first item, with "All categories" one tap away.
- **The discount rule (10% on 2, 15% on 3+) is a placeholder.** It's Zouk's business decision; the design works with any rule.

Success metrics: share of product-page visits that open "Make it a set"; share of orders containing a set; drop-off by step; items and value per order; share of sets reaching 3 items; gift orders delivered by the promised date. Guardrails: single-item sales, margin per order, returns on set orders.

Say this:

- "The key word in the brief is 'own'. Zouk already sells 130 combos, but every one is a pair Zouk chose."
- "The saving already exists in the cart. The fix is showing it while he's choosing."
- "Rohan knows why he's buying, not what to pick, so the builder does the matching."
- "I called it a 'set' on purpose. One offer already has three names."
- "The discount stops growing at three items to protect margin, and the rule fits in one line."
- "I reused the existing cart and the same filters as the collection pages, so Zouk builds less and customers learn one system."

Likely interview questions, with answer pointers

Most questions will probe your trade-offs and your evidence, so answer with the reason first, then the proof.

Question	Answer pointers
Why did you audit before starting the tasks?	All four tasks sit on the same problems (specs, reviews, prints, offers). Finding them once let each task build on the last.
You had no data. How can you be sure?	I wasn't sure, so I said so. Every finding separates observed, inferred and to-verify, and every assumption is checkable in minutes.

Question	Answer pointers
Why one persona per task, and why a woman for Task 1?	A specific person settles arguments a demographic can't. Task 1 was scoped to first-time women buyers from ads; I stated that, including who it doesn't cover.
What was the hardest trade-off?	The print switcher: it can make people slower. I chose a better decision over a faster one, and would measure switcher users separately.
Isn't showing strict return terms bad for conversion?	Maybe a little. But a buyer who finds out later costs more in trust, support and returns. And I didn't propose changing the policy, only showing it.
What would you cut if engineering had one sprint?	Reorder the gallery and add the "Will it fit?" block. Both reuse assets Zouk already has. Then clean the filter data, which is an afternoon's work.
What did competitors do better?	Mokobara: laptop fit at two levels, dimensions labelled external, delivery date before a pincode. Lino Perros: per-product reviews with tags.
What would you not copy?	Urgency tricks and stacked discounts. At the lowest price in the comparison, a calm, honest page is itself a position.
How does navigation matter if ad traffic lands on a product page?	Pivots (wrong print, wrong bag type), return visits across sessions, and the menu structure decides what ads land on.
Why "set" instead of "combo"?	"Combo" already means the 130 fixed pairs, and one offer already has three names. A new word avoids a fourth.
How would you validate all this?	A/B test against the current page for paid-ad visitors on bestsellers; read speed early, and fit-related returns after a full return window.
Where did you change your mind?	Navigation (reframed as information architecture) and the grid (group by bag, don't collapse prints into swatches).

Stories worth having ready (one minute each):

- **The capacity arithmetic:** $40.7 \times 33.1 \times 10.2 \text{ cm} = 13.74 \text{ L}$, matching the infographic's 13.8 L. The same method holds on a second bag, so it's a pattern, not a typo.
- **The two policy pages:** the page linked from the product says bags get a 2-day defect claim; Shopify's checkout policy says no exchange or refund on bags at all.
- **Wallet reviews under an office bag:** why I'd keep pooling across prints but stop pooling across product types.

What I'd do next, what I'd do differently, and how I used AI

Close on what you'd validate, not on what you'd add. It shows you know the work is a hypothesis until real users test it.

What I'd do next:

- Check my assumptions with Zouk's data: ad landing pages, on-site search terms, and return reasons.
- Run 5–8 quick usability tests with first-time buyers on the new product page and the set builder.
- Test live search ("16 inch laptop bag", "kalamkari"), which I couldn't audit because it renders in the browser.
- Agree one source of truth for product specs with the product team. Most of Task 1 depends on it.

What I'd do differently:

- Talk to even two or three real customers before designing, instead of relying only on the live site.
- Timebox the audit more tightly. It was thorough, but a smaller first pass would have let me validate earlier.

How I used AI (be ready for this question):

- Say plainly which parts AI helped with: for example, organising and wording the documents, and building parts of the Figma file.
- Say plainly which calls were yours: the problem framing, the persona, the principles, the trade-offs and the final design direction.
- Keep it factual, and make sure it matches what you've told Zouk elsewhere. Reviewers value honesty here more than a perfect story.

Open item for you: replace the AI bullets above with your own exact account before the interview.